



says with a smile. “Random messages get delivered, and I can only make or receive calls. That’s it for me. I wish I could throw this small, annoying thing...”

Instead, he prefers letters. Every morning, when he empties the mailbox, he carefully sorts through the correspondence and replies to each one.

“I reply to all of them. I read every letter and ensure that they receive my reply. That sort of keeps me busy...” he says.

A stroke in 2010 briefly disrupted his routine, but thanks to disciplined living and regular exercise, Bird lives without dietary restrictions. He still visits the Wetherby Whaler takeaway on Fridays for scampi and onion rings.

“I eat everything,” he says, stirring

his coffee and adding more milk.

As we speak, a few old friends drop by to say hello, and some younger faces recognise him too. Bird cherishes these moments, the kind of social interaction he missed deeply during the COVID-19 lockdown five summers ago.

The following day, he’s set to travel to Scarborough to watch County matches involving his beloved Yorkshire. Whenever the club plays away, Bird tries to accompany them. It gives him a chance to watch cricket, yes, but also to reconnect with coaches, club members, and friends.

In winter, he turns his attention to football. A lifelong member of Barnsley Football Club, he attends matches there frequently. Having played both cricket and football in



Bird’s eye view

* Officiated in 66 Tests and 69 One-Day Internationals

* Stood in his first match in 1970, with his Test debut coming against New Zealand at Leeds in 1973.

* In 1992, stood in Zimbabwe’s inaugural Test, becoming the first umpire from the ICC panel to do so.

* Awarded the MBE in June 1986, as part of the Queen’s Birthday Honours List.

* Co-authored several books, including *My Autobiography* with Keith Lodge, and the follow-up *White Cap and Bails*—both bestsellers.